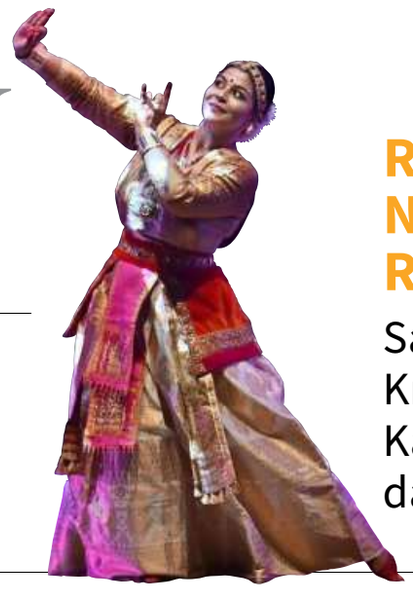
friday Review

THE HINDU

Street turns into a concert space
Mysuru's Ganapathi Festival added a unique flavour to T. M. Krishna's concert **p2**

Art of hope and compassion
The Sai Symphony Orchestra empowers children from rural communities **p4**



REFRESHING NORTHEAST RHYTHM
Sattriya exponent Krishnakshi Kashyap's new dance work **p4**



Raising the barre
Dhvani Kothari.
PHOTO COURTESY: NBSI

On Pointe

Dhvani Kothari, founder of the National Ballet School of India, is breaking down stereotypes to make the western dance form more accessible

Nivedita Jayaram Pawar

There is a fair amount of chaos in the ballet class. Little girls in leotards and tutus twirl around the room, chatter among themselves and occasionally lose their balance. Some cling to the barre, while others stretch, wobble and try to hold their positions. A few casually drop into splits as though it were the most natural thing in the world. Then the music changes. Feet turn out, backs straighten, arms rise and slowly the chaos falls into place. Watching from the side is Dhvani Kothari, founder of the National Ballet School of India. Across 12 centres in Mumbai, she now teaches more than 250 students, ranging from three-year-olds to a 44-year-old mother of two.

Her own journey into ballet was far from conventional. At 13, Dhvani had already tried jazz, contemporary and hip hop, but none felt right. Then a Russian ballet instructor visited India, and everything changed. "When I tried ballet it was an instant click. I knew I belonged to it. I can just be myself here," she says. The instructor eventually left, and Dhvani had to find her own way.

Much of her formal training happened in Croatia and Hungary. At 16, she spent six months in Croatia, later returning at 19. She also spent six months training in Hungary. But it was not easy being a late starter. "Most of the dancers in my class were aged between 10 and 12. So it was awkward being the oldest in the class. But with time, I got comfortable," she says. Competitions followed and so did wins. At 19, she won the Bosphorus Ballet Festival in Turkey, which had participants from 75 countries. "That win made me believe that Indians can also perform ballet with a formal, structured training," she says.

In 2019, Dhvani started the National Ballet School of India. Within a year, there were more than 100 students. Then the pandemic hit. Classes moved online, a particularly difficult transition for an art form that relies heavily on physical correction and movement. "Bringing ballet to a country that still didn't understand it, was in itself a struggle, and then to shift all of that to an online mode was tough. Initially, we didn't really know how it was going to work. But with a supportive set of students things began to fall in place," adds Dhvani.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 5

A Space Marketing Initiative

THE CHANGING FACE OF KNEE CARE

FROM PAIN MANAGEMENT TO PERSONALISED TREATMENT

Modern orthopaedics is moving beyond simply managing knee pain — towards understanding the individual knee, preserving natural movement where possible, and choosing the right treatment at the right time.

From treating pain to understanding the patient

Knee care has changed significantly over the years. Traditionally, the focus was often on controlling pain and improving day-to-day comfort until symptoms became severe enough to consider surgery. Today, the approach is more individualised. A painful knee is not simply a diagnosis; it is a joint with its own anatomy, alignment, cartilage health, stability, movement patterns and functional demands. Understanding these differences is the first step towards deciding what treatment is appropriate.

Preserving the knee whenever possible

This shift has also changed the way we approach knee osteoarthritis. Not every patient with arthritis needs the same treatment, and not every painful knee needs replacement. Depending on the stage of disease and condition of the joint, treatment may include physiotherapy, strengthening, weight management, activity modification, medication, injections and other joint-preservation approaches. The objective is to preserve the natural knee and maintain function for as long as clinically appropriate. Equally important is recognising when preservation is no longer sufficient and replacement may provide a better path forward.

Looking beyond the X-ray

Personalised treatment means looking beyond an X-ray. Two patients may show similar changes on an image but experience very different levels of pain and limitation. Clinical examination, symptoms, alignment, bone and soft-tissue condition, activity levels and individual expectations all contribute to treatment decisions. This is where clinical judgement and experience remain central. Technology can provide valuable information and precision, but it cannot replace the understanding of the patient behind the image.

The role of informed decisions

A personalised approach also means involving patients in decisions about their care. Understanding the likely benefits, limitations and timing of each option allows patients to make informed choices that fit their health, lifestyle and priorities. Regular assessment is important because the condition of a knee can change over time. The aim is not to rush towards surgery or postpone it unnecessarily, but to recognise when the balance has changed and a different treatment may offer greater benefit at that particular stage in life

When replacement becomes the right choice

When knee replacement becomes necessary, advances in technology have added another dimension to personalised care. Mako Stryker robotic-assisted knee replacement uses CT-based three-dimensional planning to create a surgical plan based on the patient's individual anatomy. Robotic assistance can then help the surgeon execute the planned positioning and alignment with precision. The technology is not a substitute for the surgeon; it is a tool that works alongside surgical expertise and judgement.

The future is personalised

The future of knee care is not about choosing between preservation and replacement, or between experience and technology. It is about bringing them together thoughtfully. The right treatment is the one that matches the patient's condition, goals and stage of disease. Whether the objective is to preserve the natural knee, manage symptoms effectively or restore function through replacement, modern orthopaedics is increasingly centred on one principle.

Treat the patient, not just the knee.



Dr.Deepak Kumar K S
MBBS, MS(Orthopedics), MCH(Ortho)
Chief Consultant - Orthopedic surgeon
Knee Replacement and Mako Stryker Expert
23 Years of Experience



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A CH-CHE



Creative cadence T.M. Krishna with Tiruvananthapuram Sampath and B. Sivaraman. PHOTOS: K J PAVAN & M PRABHU PRASAD

Street-side Carnatic story

T.M. Krishna turned Mysuru's 8th Cross into a musical lab to explore how space, repertoire and listening shape a concert

Vighnesh Hampapura

It had been many years since the Mysuru audience witnessed T.M. Krishna begin a concert with a varnam, as has been the Carnatic convention. He was at the 8th Cross Ganapathi Music Festival, organised by SPVGMC Trust, with Tiruvananthapuram Sampath on the violin, B. Sivaraman on the mridangam and Guruprasad on the ghatam. At this pandal that celebrates 65 years of bringing music to - literally - the street, the audience sat before him and to his right, spread in an L-arrangement (a new feature this year). Krishna opened his concert with the Ata tala varnam 'Sarasijanabha'.

Even so, there were no regulations governing his music, only timely possibilities: out of nowhere, like the stretch of the phrase had split open a byway, Krishna embarked on a niraval at the anupallavi, 'Niratamu nee'. In a sweeping single round, he covered three octaves, and with the same momentum continued in a different kalapramana.

While he usually sketches Kamboji with serenity, cued by 'O rangasayee', 'Sri subrahmanyaya namaste' or 'Tiruvadi sharanam', the markers of this presentation were its robustness and muscularity, especially as the niraval built to a crescendo.

Sampath was in full form in the very first song. Krishna's manodharma mostly hinges on a phrase: when you find an interesting *pakad*, as Hindustani musicians would call it, you must hover around it and explore its many variations. The sarvalaghu cocooning phrase 'ma ga ma ri ga sa pa ma pa ga ma ga...' in the third ettugade swara was one such *pakad*. Krishna egged his violinist on to stay with the phrase and work around it for the swaraprastara, where otherwise the temptation may have been to move linearly, forward and backward.

Eight years ago, Krishna's 'Sarasijanabha' presentation at Mysuru's Ganabharathi, stretching for about 40 minutes, was suffused with a soft tonality. This rendition, though, with more gusto, gave us a different experience. At points, the sheer power one was bracing for was such that – with the mridangam no doubt adding volume – Krishna's voice, slightly ajar, the acoustics as good as they could be on a road - one had to wonder if this was a new turn in his music.



The rest of the concert put an end to such speculation, for we were led into a contemplative territory, first transported to a reposeful Yamunakalyani and the familiarity of his much-cherished 'Jambupathe.' A few years ago, Krishna brought the kriti back to its accurate, tranquil version. The 8th Cross edition gained even more poise as Sivaraman and Guruprasad chose not to complement, a wise accompaniment decision. There has, perhaps, not been a single occasion when Krishna reaches 'Anirvachaneeya nada bindo' without everyone and everything falling silent. It must be observed, if only to note how space affects musical experience, that there was a strange restlessness among the audience, in my estimation, because the agape atmosphere did not fully allow the kind of singular immersion that 'Jambupathe' inspires.

What followed was 'Chinna nade na' in raga Kalanidhi, immortalised by the legendary flautist T.R. Mahalingam. The music festival was dedicated to his memory on the occasion of his birth centenary year.

After a binding Dhanyasi alapana, Krishna took up 'Meena lochana'. The singing showcased the uniqueness of Syama Sastri's style, in which the phrases coalesce around one another – only accentuated by the specific gamakas of Dhanyasi. The composition is intense rather than expansive, like 'Sangeeta gnanamu' in the same raga. 'Meena lochana' takes musicians of true regard to apprehend and recreate its compact and dense universe. It was clear Krishna was experiencing and manifesting the difference Syama Sastri brings to the raga. His singing reminded us that a raga is not fully formed, emptied into a composition in parts and parcels, but that a specific aesthetic of a raga emerges from a good kriti.

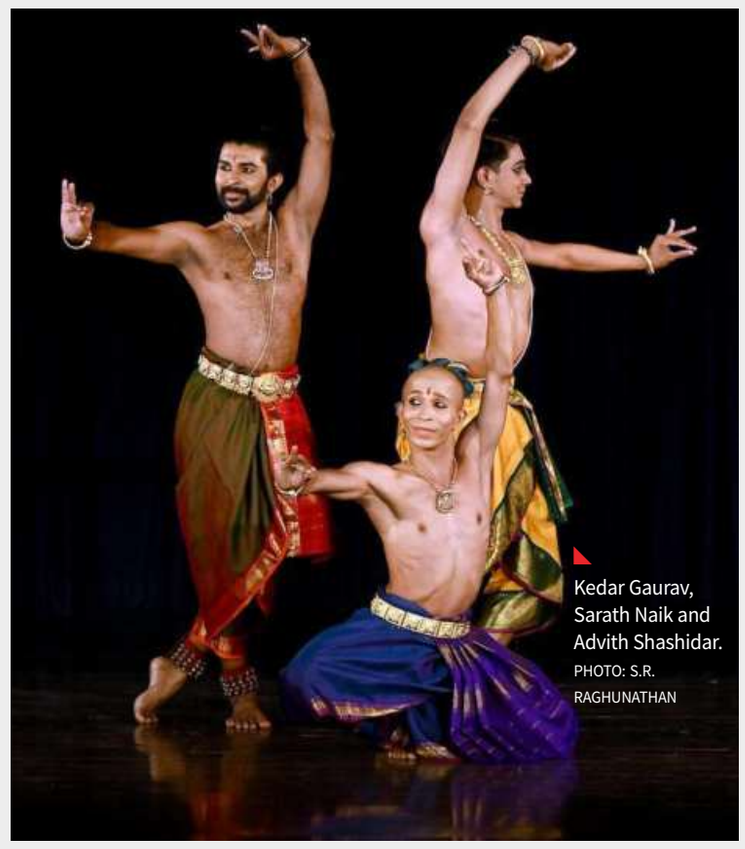
Accordingly, in one of the most beautiful kalpanaswaras, the gandhara traversed the entire raga and returned, without ever seeming like the singer had ascended and descended through the many notes of the raga's scale. Even when Krishna expanded a phrase to a larger set of notes, he had to spin through the entirety of the range. Sivaraman's mridangam layered this presentation with its own repetitive charm. Krishna exploited the musically complex rhyme scheme in the charanam, and hung the final notes on a different hook every time. The resultant shifting of enjambments, in a clustered composition such as this one, ensured that we heard a percussive variation in the very instruments of melody: the voice and the violin.

Given that the thani continues to carry the trace of the immediate composition, for the percussion to have continued without a break after 'Meena lochana' might have ushered in a kind of claustrophobia. Fortunately, a vigorous thani only came after the next song, 'Nadopasana' in Begada. Throughout, Guruprasad's patterns were innovative. The kriti clearly contrasted Tyagaraja's style with Syama Sastri's.

After 'Tunga teera virajam', in Salagabhairavi (rather than Yamunakalyani, which he presented a month ago in Mysuru), there was a sense that the music for the day was done, even as music never suffices, amongst some audience members and perhaps Krishna himself, who was at a loss about the next number. He emphasised that insatiability when he performed three audience requests one after the other: 'Irakkam varamal' in Behag, 'Eppo varuvaro' in Jhonpuri, and 'Maye tvam yahi' in the Tarangini of the *Sangita Sampradaya Pradarshini*. All melodies of pleading, he left us in a state of longing even after a grand concert of three hours.

Over to the narthaka

An annual dance festival that provides a platform for young male artistes



Kedar Gaurav, Sarath Naik and Advith Shashidar. PHOTO: S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

V.V. Ramani

It has always been an uphill task for male dancers to get performance opportunities. Seeking to address this gap, Natyanjali Trust, led by Prema Satish, launched a festival dedicated to male dancers. Since its inception in 2007, the Narthaka Festival has consistently showcased talented male dancers, giving them the much-deserved platform.

This year's edition, a two-day festival, featured three young dancers, Kedar Gaurav, Sarath Naik and Advith Shashidar, who are currently training under Indira Kadambi. On the occasion, Kuchipudi exponent MVN Murthy was presented the Lifetime Achievement Award.

The performance began with the dancers coming together for the Pushpanjali before moving on to present individual compositions.

Narasimha stotra by Adi Shankaracharya and Narasimha Kavuthuvam in ragamalika were performed by Sarath Naik. The dancer depicted Narasimha's form evocatively, seamlessly weaving episodes from the story of Prahlada into his narrative. His transition from a gentle Prahlada to a fierce Narasimha was marked by clarity and conviction.

The popular Vasantha raga kriti by Gopalakrishnan Bharathi – 'Natanam Aadinar' – was performed by Kedar Gurav. This composition is particularly well suited to male dancers. Kedar's exploration of the iconic imagery – the Dancing Lord holding udukkai in one hand and a ball of fire in the other, the flowing locks, the crescent moon and the demon beneath His feet – was vibrant and fast-paced. A little more restraint, however, would have lent grace to the nritta.

'Kadhiruvenu Rama', Ambujam Krishna's beautiful composition in raga Ranjani, highlighted the steadfast devotion and surrender to Rama as seen through the exemplary bhakti of Shabari, Jatayu and Hanuman. Advith Shashidar entered the stage as Jatayu and briefly portrayed the bird's majestic flight and valiant battle with Ravana, leading to the loss of his wings and his final moments with Rama. He then transformed into Shabari, waiting for Rama's arrival and lovingly plucking fruits for Him, before donning the role of Hanuman. Advith went on to portray Hanuman's visit to Asoka Vana and the *choodamani pradhanam*. Advith's sensitivity and evocative expression stood out.

The symmetry and coordination among the three dancers was noteworthy in 'Swarakattu', a composition by Tanjore Sivanandam in raga Thodi, choreographed by guru Narmada. The entries and exits were neatly executed by the dancers. However, the pace at which they performed gave the impression that they were rushing through the presentation. This diluted the aesthetic appeal of the dance.

Having undergone meticulous training, the dancers now need to cultivate a distinctive approach to their art.



Musical tapestry Padmashree Srinivasan with Usha Rajagopalan; Kumbakonam Swaminathan; and Madipakkam Murali. PHOTO: B. VELANKANNI RAJ

A unifying thread

The thematic focus brought together kritis by various composers

Aishwarya Raghunathan

Sri Thyaga Brahma Gana Sabha's concert series as part of its 15th Sri Jayanthi music festival, featured Padmashree Srinivasan's performance. She was accompanied by Usha Rajagopalan on the violin, Kumbakonam K. Swaminathan on the mridangam and Madipakkam A. Murali on the ghatam.

Padmashree opened with Veena Kuppaiyer's 'Sami nee thodi' in Kamavardhini, a varnam addressed to Lord Rajagopala. The charanam, with its evocation of the anguish of separation, set the emotional tenor for the concert built entirely around Krishna.

A brief alapana of Kedaragowla followed, with Usha Rajagopalan's rich raga contours, during her responses, enhancing the appeal of the rendition. The choice of kriti was Tyagaraja's 'Venugana lolane', which gathered momentum through Swaminathan's rhythmic mridangam accompaniment, particularly at the niraval line 'Vikasita pada', followed by a vibrant round of kalpanaswaras. Murali on the ghatam lent a pleasing tonal dimension to the charanam through his playing.

Padmashree's next was Swati Tirunal's 'Gopalaka pahimam anisham'. Though the kriti began on a sedate note, its madhyama kala passages carried a buoyant mood, which was followed by a lively round of kalpanaswaras.

What saved the thematic concert from predictability was its diverse selection of composers, ragas and kritis.

A virutham in Sahana, 'Krishnaya vasudevaya', paved the way for Oothukkadu Venkata Subba Iyer's 'Vasudevaya namo namaste'. Here, the violin closely followed and reflected the vocal line, while the mridangam and ghatam engaged in a rhythmic conversation. The recital then moved to G.N. Balasubramaniam's popular 'Mohana krishna' in Kathanakuthuhalam.

The main piece of the concert was Muthuswami Dikshitar's 'Sri krishnam bhaja manasa', which was preceded by a well-rounded alapana in Thodi. The raga was explored with restraint and clarity, setting the stage for a poised rendering of the kriti. An elaborate niraval at 'Sankha chakra' was notable for its lucidity, before the swara passages unfolded with ease and fluency.

Just before the tani avartanam, Padmashree and the percussionists exchanged a few words on stage, an informal moment that preceded an engaging rhythmic dialogue. The tani was distinguished by the crisp articulation of sollus from both the mridangam and ghatam. Swaminathan and Murali played with a pleasing sense of balance. The exchange gathered momentum towards a neatly executed 32-beat korvai, bringing the tani to a clean finish.

As the concert drew towards its close, the focus returned to the three pasurams of Periyazhwar, 'Tan mugathu chutti, 'En sirukuttan' and 'Azhagiya vaayan', sung in Desh, followed by 'Hey Gopalaka', a virutham from *Mukundamala*, in raga Sindhu Bhairavi. Its evocative phrases led seamlessly into Narayana Tirtha's 'Kalyana gopalam', which Padmashree rendered with an easy warmth, allowing the bhakti to remain at the heart of the music.

The reflective mood then gave way to the rhythmic sparkle of Lalgudi Jayaraman's Madhuvanti thillana. The evening finally settled into Madhyamavati with 'Mangalam thunga', from Oothukkadu Venkatasubbaiyer's *Madhava Panchakam*. It was an apt and unhurried close to a recital that had remained faithful to its Krishna theme from beginning to end.

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Assamese heritage Krishnakshi Kashyap and her ensemble. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Sattriya's new expression

Krishnakshi Kashyap explores the five elements to expand the dance form's choreographic vocabulary

Swapnanil Barua

Sarvabhutatma Sri Krishna, choreographed by Krishnakshi Kashyap, uses the Panchabhuta (the five elements) as a dramaturgical framework to explore Krishna's leelas and his presence as the consciousness that pervades creation.

On a full-house evening, at the Sri Sri Madhavdeva International Auditorium of Srimanta Sankaradeva Kalakshetra, Guwahati, Sattriyakristi presented *Sarvabhutatma Sri Krishna - Five Elements, One Krishna* – a Sattriya dance production, conceptualised and choreographed by Krishnakshi Kashyap. The production sought to view Krishna not merely as the protagonist of familiar episodes from the Bhagavata tradition, but as the all-pervading principle of consciousness through which Nature itself can be apprehended.

The conceptual premise was both simple and ambitious: to place the five elemental forces of Nature – prithvi, jal, agni, vayu and akash – at the centre of Krishna's divine manifestations. Within this framework, familiar episodes acquire a symbolic dimension. The lifting of Govardhan is associated with earth, Kaliya Daman with water, Krishna's consumption of the raging forest fire with fire, the music of his flute with air, and the revelation of the Vishwarupa to Arjuna with the boundlessness of Space.

The idea of relating the Panchabhuta to Krishna offers a dramaturgical medium through which the production moves from the tangible to the metaphysical. The progression eventually leads to the larger proposition suggested by the title itself: Sarvabhutatma – Krishna as the indwelling essence of all beings and elements.

What makes the production noteworthy is the attempt to communicate this philosophical premise primarily through the grammar of Sattriya. The choreography maintains a balance between suddha nritya and abhinaya. The former provides the kinetic architecture for the production, while the latter gives a narrative form to the episodes being evoked.

The pure dance passages were particularly engaging in the manner in which they ventured beyond the familiar movement vocabulary of Chali dances while remaining recognisably rooted in the Sattriya idiom. There was technical precision in the execution, but equally important was the quality of *Ulaah* – that characteristic grace and buoyancy which gives Sattriya much of its distinctive visual personality.

Another strength was the ensemble work. The dancers moved with considerable synchronisation across the different choreographic sections. Such uniformity is not merely an aesthetic virtue in group choreography; it is an indication of sustained rehearsal and a shared understanding of the choreographic language. The visual coherence of the ensemble allowed the larger idea of the production to remain at the forefront.

The production also derives considerable strength from its engagement with the literary and devotional heritage of Assam. The textual material, assembled and translated from diverse sources and partly composed by Bhaskar Jyoti Ojah, draws upon *Srimad Bhagavata* as well as Srimanta Sankardeva's *Kirtan Ghoxa* and Sri Sri Madhavdeva's *Naam Ghoxa*.

The musical design, also directed by Ojah, reflects a similar attempt to locate the production within Assam's devotional soundscape. Borgeet, Bhatima, Prasangia Sur, Dihanam and Malita are woven into the musical structure. Rather than functioning merely as accompaniment, these forms help establish the cultural and spiritual milieu of the production.

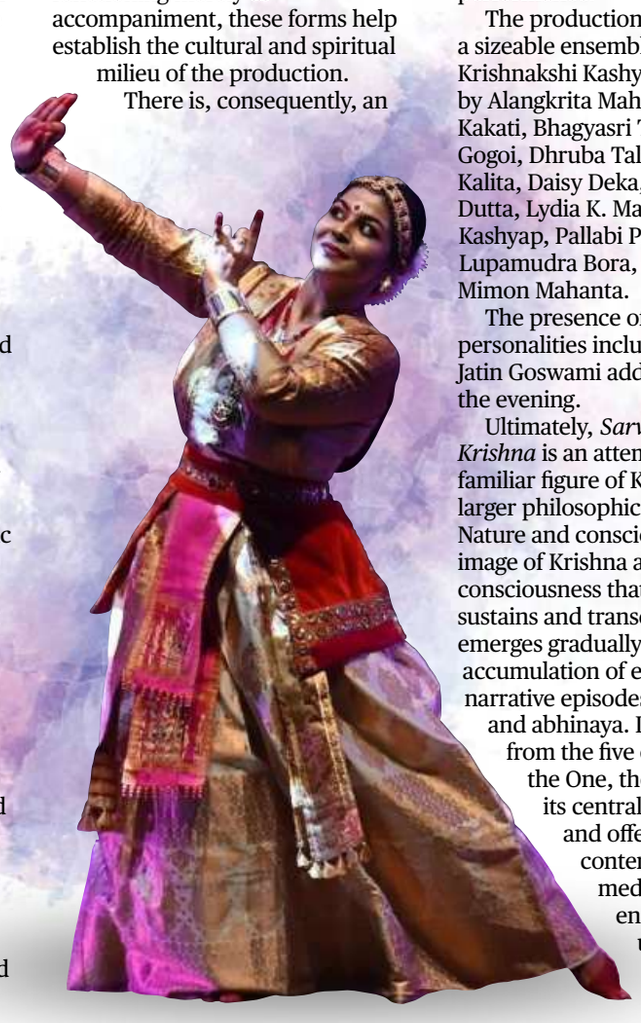
There is, consequently, an interesting dialogue between the traditional and the contemporary throughout . The subject is ancient, the textual sources are rooted in the devotional tradition, and the musical vocabulary draws substantially from established forms. Yet the choreographic architecture seeks to reorganise this material around a conceptual proposition that is distinctly contemporary in its presentation.

The evening began with performances by the youngest students of Sattriyakristi, who presented Krishna Nritya and Mati Akhara – two foundational components of Sattriya training. Sattriyakristi, led by Krishnakshi, combines training with repertory-building, thereby attempting to address both dimensions of the tradition's continuity – its transmission and its performance.

The production brought together a sizeable ensemble, with Krishnakshi Kashyap accompanied by Alangkrita Mahanta, Archita Kakati, Bhagyasri Talukdar, Suraj Gogoi, Dhruba Talukdar, Hiyajuri Kalita, Daisy Deka, Shyamontika Dutta, Lydia K. Marak, Leeja Kashyap, Pallabi Phangcho, Lupamudra Bora, Ankita Amchi and Mimon Mahanta.

The presence of eminent personalities including Nrityacharya Jatin Goswami added significance to the evening.

Ultimately, *Sarvabhutatma Sri Krishna* is an attempt to locate the familiar figure of Krishna within the larger philosophical landscape of Nature and consciousness. The final image of Krishna as the consciousness that pervades, sustains and transcends creation emerges gradually through the accumulation of elemental imagery, narrative episodes, rhythm, gesture and abhinaya. In that movement from the five elements towards the One, the production finds its central artistic idea – and offers a contemporary Sattriya meditation on the enduring universality of Krishna.



Making the right choice

Kalyanapuram S. Aravind delights with a carefully curated repertoire



The vocalist with L. Ramakrishnan on the violin, B. Sivaraman on the mridangam and Nerkunam Sankar on the kanjira. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

R. Revathi

Kalyanapuram S. Aravind's concert was fittingly marked by the magnificent composition by Muthuswami Dikshitar, 'Sri subramanyaya namaste' (Kamboji), as the event, organised by Kedaram Trust, was in memory of N.V. Subramaniam, founder of Saraswathi and Saraswathi Vaggeyakara Trust.

Aravind's unhurried Kamboji alapana was the highlight of the evening as he made the raga's identity clear in the very first phrase. L. Ramakrishnan's violin response systematically built the raga before concluding with the characteristic phrase in kakali nishadam in the lower octave.

The verse 'Senthanai kandhanai sengottu verpanai', from Arunagirinathar's *Kandhar Alankaram*, led to the 'Sri subramanyaya namaste.' The jaru phrases drew attention. The tempo allowed the distinctive aspects of Kamboji to be heard clearly. The latter part of the charanam, usually heard in madhyama kala, was rendered in the same tempo as the kriti.

The niraval at the anupallavi line 'Vasavadi sakala deva vanditaya,' brought the lyrics into focus. The use of upper octave for 'sakala deva' was especially effective, after which the kalpanaswaras initially settled around that register. Math and melody seemed to meet naturally here. B. Sivaraman on the mridangam and Nerkunam Sankar on the kanjira picked up the rhythmic possibilities in the tisra eka exchanges, with its three beats to a cycle, and moved smoothly through the tani avartanam, building it towards an intricate *koraippu*.

Aravind brought the same grip to the kritis rendered prior to the main piece. Tyagaraja's 'Evarikai avataramethithivo', in Devamanohari, with a brief alapana, was a straightforward rendition without the manodharma embellishments. 'Manasuloni marmamulu', in Hindolam, was brisk with kalpanaswaras at the same pace. The anchoring around Dhaivatam in phrases, shared between Aravind and Ramakrishnan, made for an engaging evening, though a few passages ventured beyond the comfortable upper vocal range.

The opening Navaragamalika varnam, aptly beginning with the raga Kedaram and the shloka 'Dharani garbha sambhutham' leading to Dikshitar's 'Angarakamashrayamyaham ', set the concert on its course. Muthiah Bhagavatar's 'Sarasa dala nayane' in Saramathi, with its unhurried chittaswaram, composed by Aravind's guru, Madurai T.N. Seshagopalan, led the concert to a dainty Purvikalyani alapana followed by yet another Tyagaraja composition 'Gnanamosaga rada.' With phrases in tanam-style structure, the niraval at the line 'Paripurna nishkalanka' was a brilliant exercise both by Aravind and Ramakrishnan.

Towards the end came the evening's lively moment. Aravind started 'Siruviralgal thadavi,' a Periyazhwar pasuram, in Thodi and continued it as a ragamalika virutham. At the line 'Govindan kuzhal kondu oodhina podhu,' the creativity began to move across a gamut of ragas. Hamir Kalyani was followed by short phrases of Bhairavi alternating with Sindhu Bhairavi, with Ramakrishnan bringing in Vasantha and Kalyana Vasantham for his part on the violin. Aravind moved through Vasantha Bhairavi, Salaga Bhairavi and Khamas before arriving at Rageshri for the Surdas bhajan, 'Krishna nama rasana,' making it a small feast on its own.

The ability to make musical ideas audible without overindulging in them made this concert an appropriate tribute to N.V. Subramaniam. Aravind's concert was one where the details mattered, but never had to be announced.

CALENDAR



Pancharatna pendant for Meenakshi

During his recent visit to the Sri Meenakshi Amman temple, Madurai, following its consecration, Sri Sankara Vijayendra Saraswati, the 70th Acharya of the Kanchi Kamakoti Math, offered a Pancharatna pendant and a gold necklace to the goddess. The offering was inspired by *Sri Meenakshi Pancharatnam*, the hymn composed by Adi Shankaracharya in praise of the deity.

Vocal solo

The Music Academy has organised Ranjani Ravindrabharathy's vocal concert on October 5, 6 p.m. as part of HCL concerts. V. Mridula (violin) and Veeramraju Lakshmi Ajay (mridangam) are the accompanists. Venue: Kasturi Srinivasan Hall.



Music competition

Sri Thyaga Brahma Gana Sabha invites applications from those below the age group of 25 for music competitions, held from October 3 to 4, 10 a.m. at Vani Mahal, T. Nagar.

On October 3, participants are required to sing kritis of Tyagaraja and Syama Sastri, while on October 4, it is Dikshitar and Sivan kritis. A veena contest will also be held on the concluding day.

Applications can be downloaded on www.vanimahal.com.

Rural rhapsody

How the Sai Symphony Orchestra is nurturing talented youngsters from rural communities

Malini White

When we think of a symphony orchestra, we usually imagine an ensemble of Western musicians playing the works of Mozart, Beethoven, and Brahms. But meet the members of the unique Sai Symphony Orchestra, established in 2014.

India's biggest home-grown orchestra, established under the guidance of One World One Family's founder Sri Madhusudan Sai, it comprises more than 150 children from rural and disadvantaged backgrounds, who belong to organisation's free schools in Muddenahalli, in the outskirts of Bengaluru. Its repertoire spans genres and eras.

Recently, the orchestra played at the One World One Family''s fundraiser at the West End, with Sunil Gavaskar as the chief guest.

What began as a brass band in 2015, morphed into an orchestra in 2020, with a full complement of strings, brass, wind instruments and percussion. Sri Madhusudan then decided that besides just creating music, the orchestra would "discover the hidden potential of rural youth, nurturing their talent and empowering them with the confidence and values to become changemakers in society".

The amazing leap to international significance came in 2025, when it earned an entry into the Guinness World Records, having brought together 450 musicians from 65 nationalities in a single choral symphony. In June this year, 24 of its musicians played at the Hofburg Palace in Vienna. And they have performed with, or for, international music greats such as L. Subramaniam, Ricky Kej and A.R. Rahman, who have lauded their talent and commitment. The organisation's initiatives have inspired many global personalities from different fields to contribute towards its mission. Among them is Dimitris Lambrianos, a Greek-American musician and educator, who has trained the students. Proficient in over 30 instruments, he has performed at prestigious international venues. Moved by the mission's free hospital services during his visit to India 10 years ago, Dimitris decided to stay back to teach and guide the young members of the orchestra.



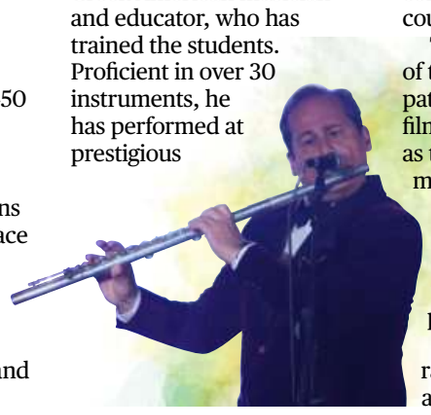


Symphonic harmony (Clockwise from left) Members of the Sai Symphony Orchestra; Dimitris Lambrianos and Jeevan Sai. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

It is amazing that these students have been able to master Western classical instruments, which they had probably never seen before in their lives! This includes the mini harp, rarely seen on concert platforms in the country.

The recent performance of the orchestra included patriotic songs and popular film numbers, with Harikesh as the conductor. As a result, most pieces sounded similar. A change of mood and tempo came with Mozart's 'Turkish March' with Jeevan Sai on the piano.

The evening of melody raised hope for both art and society.



On pointe



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Running the school also meant taking on responsibilities beyond dance. "I was young and didn't really understand the business aspect of it, but was keen to introduce ballet to more young enthusiasts. Eventually, I learned to balance the creative and administrative aspects," she says. Dhvani had to develop a curriculum, introduce exams and competitions, organise shows and build a team. The school follows the Vaganova method of Russian ballet, known for its rigorous training and emphasis on technique. Students follow a structured syllabus over seven to eight years.

There are still several misconceptions around the dance form in India that she has to deal with, one of them being that ballet is only for girls and merely a hobby rather than a serious form of training. There is also an assumption that beginners start dancing en pointe from the outset. In reality, pointe work usually comes much later and depends on a dancer's ankle, core strength and level of training. Dhvani also wants to dismantle the idea that ballet is only for thin bodies. "Ballet is for every body type, because there is really no limitation to how you do it," she says.

Another challenge is the shortage of male dancers. The school currently has only six boys, and the gap becomes particularly evident during performances. "A proper classical ballet routine requires male dancers too, as certain roles demand their presence. I hope to see more boys pursue this form," Dhvani says.

The infrastructure for ballet in India is gradually improving. Mumbai now has venues such as the Royal Opera House and NMACC, but Dhvani feels there are still very few spaces suitable for a full-scale ballet production. Studios often lack sprung flooring. When she began training in India, she says, dancers would practise on marble floors.

For Dhvani, ballet is not something that ends when the class is over. "Every aspect of my life is linked to the dance form. My sleep, diet and even thought process are shaped by ballet. And no, I don't survive on salads alone. I include plenty of protein in my meals and occasionally indulge in a slice of chocolate cake," she shares.



Movement vocabulary Dhvani Kothari and students of her ballet school. PHOTOS COURTESY: NBSI

Her larger ambition, however, goes beyond getting more children into ballet classes. At present, students who want to pursue ballet professionally have to leave the country for advanced training and opportunities. "We train them and then watch them leave. Ideally, I would like to see them perform and build their careers here."

The thought that a ballerina is a performer and is meant to be on stage is changing. Dhvani and her dancers have worked on film sets, provided movement direction for Bollywood actors and collaborated with brands and cultural institutions. The school also stages its own productions and has built a growing network of students and teachers, creating more opportunities for ballet in India.

Back in the studio, the music starts again. The girls return to the barre, straighten their backs and stretch their arms into position. For Dhvani, this is where the work begins.



Landmark show



Narthaki Global Media presents the 25th performance of 'Naachiyar Next', Anita Ratnam's acclaimed production exploring the life, poetry and enduring presence of Andal, the Tamil poet-saint. 'Naachiyar Next' is a re-telling of Anita's production, 'Naachiyar', which premiered in 2003. The work embodies a feminist reading of Andal, whose poems have come to represent female desire, personal bhakti and transgressions across the borders of conformity. It will be staged on October 3 (6 p.m.) at Rukmini Arangham, Kalakshetra. Tickets at KYN.



The National Chamber Orchestra of Armenia performing at the Music Academy. (Below) Conductor and artistic director Sipan Olah. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Music beyond geography

A concert that traced Armenia's culture and history

Kalyan Gopalan

Music can travel across borders without needing a passport. That was evident at the Armenian and European classical concert presented recently by the National Chamber Orchestra of Armenia at the Music Academy, Chennai, on September 24. It was part of the celebrations marking the 35th anniversary of Armenia's independence.

Hosted by Shivkumar Eashwaran, Honorary Consul General of the Republic of Armenia, the evening brought together a 21-member chamber orchestra under the direction of conductor and artistic director Sipan Olah. Violinist Astghik Vardanyan, pianist Katarine Hovsepyan and soprano Shoghig Torossian joined the ensemble for a programme that moved from Armenian classical music and folk-inspired works to ballet excerpts and European compositions.

Armenian music carries within it a remarkable layering of history, spirituality and cultural resilience. Its traditions encompass the austerity of monophonic folk song, the expressive contours of sacred music and the more elaborate vocabulary of concert music. The programme, comprising 13 pieces, offered glimpses into this diverse landscape.

A central figure in the preservation and development of Armenian musical identity is Komitas Vardapet, whose meticulous documentation of folk traditions helped connect the musical life of Armenian villages with the concert platform. His *Al Ailughs* was among the works presented, providing an important reminder of the folk roots that continue to inform Armenian art music.

The evening's most intriguing point of convergence with India came through Arno Babajanian's 'Nocturne'. Listening to the piece, one was struck by similarities in the melodic contours of the song 'Tu mera jaanu' from the 1983 Hindi film *Hero*, composed by Laxmikant-Pyarelal. Whether it is coincidence or influence, the resemblance was unmistakable. Katarine's piano established the nocturnal atmosphere before the strings gradually took over the principal melody, eventually returning to the piano. The effect was less a literal depiction of night than an evocation of its stillness – music that seemed to linger rather than move forward.

Such moments also revealed Olah's sensitivity to the relationship between individual sections and the larger musical architecture. The ensemble displayed considerable attention to unified bowing, intonation, tone, phrasing, vibrato and articulation.

In Khachatur Avetisian's 'Blossomed Cherry Tree', the interplay between piano, contrasting instrumental voices and pizzicato passages created a finely textured sonic surface. 'Parlami d'amore, Mariù', the Italian romantic song, brought the soprano into focus, with Torossian shaping the melodic line against the flowing strings. The gradual crescendo towards the upper register was handled with control, allowing the voice to remain integrated with the ensemble rather than dominating it.



Charles Aznavour's 'She', with music by Aznavour and lyrics by Herbert Kretzmer, offered another change of mood. Olah took the vocal line himself; his controlled phrasing, supported by the strings, and bringing to the piece the understated intimacy associated with the song.

Aram Khachaturian's 'Sabre Dance' provided a sharp contrast. Its rhythmic propulsion and rapid exchanges between instrumental sections highlighted the precision of the chamber ensemble. The dialogue between violins, violas, cellos and double basses gave the familiar work an energy that felt both tightly controlled and spontaneous.

The closing piece 'Our Beloved Yerevan', also by Babajanian, brought together Torossian and Olah in a vocal harmony. By then, the distinction between performers and audience had begun to dissolve, with Olah inviting the listeners into the celebration. The applause became part of the conclusion, turning the finale into a shared expression of Armenian musical identity.

The evening demonstrated how musical traditions, separated by geography, can find common ground in melody, rhythm, tonal colour and, ultimately, the emotional language of music.

For Chennai, a city with an enduring and vibrant concert tradition, such encounters are valuable. The Armenian ensemble's visit underlined the possibilities of creating a more sustained platform for international chamber music, allowing audiences here to discover artistic traditions beyond the familiar repertoire.

CALENDAR

Memorial concert

Under the auspices of Madhuradhwani, the following violin recital has been organised by Sri Chandrasekhara Gurukrpa, in memory of Prof. T.R. Subramanyam. Details: October 4, 6.15 p.m.: S. Varadarajan (violin) will be accompanied by Neyveli B. Venkatesh on the mridangam and N. Guruprasad on the ghatam. Venue: Arkay Convention Centre, Mylapore.

Sita kalyanam

Sri Gopalakrishna Nama Prachara Sabha has organised Sita Kalyana mahotsavam to be performed today at 9.30 a.m. at Sri Alamelumanga Kalyana Mandapam, T. Nagar. The event begins with unchavritti at 8 a.m., followed by the release of the festival souvenir at 10.30 a.m. Anjaneya utsavam at 1 p.m. will bring the utsavam to a close.







Inheritance of loss

Virasat reimagines Mahesh Elkunchwar's iconic *Wada* trilogy, a chronicle of a feudal family's decline

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A visceral, three-hour tour de force, *Virasat* distills Mahesh Elkunchwar's iconic *Wada Trilogy* into a poignant saga of a feudal family decaying from within. It is a powerful allegory that speaks fluently to the present, capturing how the slow erosion of human values and environment continues to shape our world today.

Director Anuradha Kapur reimagines her 2013 experiment with a hyperrealistic arena, set by scenographer Deepan Sivaraman, at New Delhi's Sunder Nursery, doing away with the traditional stage to immerse the audience in a living, breathing landscape. As the audience watches a family suffer from the gradual loss of their land and history while surrounded by the lush biodiversity of a beautifully-restored Mughal-era park, the contrast haunts.

Old timers remember the 2013 staging as a critically-acclaimed experience that proved Elkunchwar's sprawling trilogy could be condensed into a single evening. But it unfolded within the controlled institutional walls of the National School of Drama (NSD) Repertory Company. The performance, at Sunder Nursery, however, completely breaks free from those institutional constraints. Commissioned by the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art and rebuilt with a fresh cast, the production sheds its guise as an experiment. Anuradha, along with Sivaraman, creates spatial dramaturgy in which the physical environment actively tells the story. The Saturday performance had to be stopped midway as the monsoon played spoilsport. On Sunday, the simulated birdsong found an acoustic duet with Delhi's evening parakeets, and the heavy air carried the aroma of the kitchen fire straight into the audience, turning the tragedy into a lived-in reality.

In this immersive setting of the *wada* – a sprawling ancestral mansion – the audience sits on all four sides of it, merely feet away from the actors. Sivaraman forces you to become an uninvited guest inside the Deshpande family's intimate domestic bubble.

The play opens in the 1970s, in Dharangaon, when the Deshpande family has just cremated its patriarch, Tatyaji, resulting in a bitter resentment that immediately fractures the household. The Deshpandes possess stature, but lack the actual liquidity to even pay for the patriarch's funeral rites. Bhaskar, the eldest son, grows bitter because he stays behind to manage the crumbling estate, while his younger brother, Sudhir, leaves to Mumbai seeking a job.

While the brothers fight over the inheritance and the family's gold, their sister Prabha, waits in vain for an education she is keen to pursue. The women are trapped in the kitchen, their lives reduced to a repetitive routine of cooking and cleaning as the hypocritical men try to lure them with greed for gold, turning them into foot soldiers in their own petty wars while keeping the facade of feudalism intact.

As the feudal path completely disintegrates, Bhaskar's son Parag inherits the burdens of the land, joining hands with market forces that exploit his needs for profit. Instead of breaking free, Parag gradually hardens, giving us hope that humanity survives the apocalypse. His wife, Nandini, represents the emergence of the modern, self-actualised Indian woman who actively subverts the suffocating patterns of the household.

Between the lines, through the Deshpande family's generational saga up to the 1990s, Anuradha maps the painful transformation of post-Independence India. The collapse of a single rural Brahmin household serves as a symbol for the fading of feudal systems, agrarian distress, environmental crisis, and the dawn of predatory capitalism that moves in sync with patriarchy.

The play doesn't project standard heroes. Instead, domestic disputes and rhythmic daily routines collide to give it the shape of an epic. The domestic grind of bathing, changing the sacred thread or adjusting a sari connects seamlessly with the desperate attempt to wash away the family's encroaching moral

Splintered emotions From Anuradha Kapur's *Virasat* staged at Sunder Nursery in Delhi. PHOTOS COURTESY: KNMA



taint. The house feels like a black hole that swallows individual ambitions. While characters, such as Prabha and Anjali, yearn to escape, the structure drags them back into the unending labour of keeping the household running and the architecture of patriarchy in the *wada* intact.

Like Elkunchwar, Anuradha ensures the most profound truths are not shouted into thin air. She expects the audience to find them between the lines. It is a welcome relief from the essays that are thrown at us from various creative stages these days in the name of entertainment. It is a joy to discover the truth in the pauses of an accomplished cast that lives the text. For instance, the play captures the psychological paralysis of a generation that cannot let go of its perceived superiority. Bhaskar, immaculately depicted by Yash Yogi, clings to old structures, while Himanshu Kohli as Sudhir effectively brings out the everyday dilemmas of a son who left the village to build a better life in the city. Sajida Saji powerfully captures the plight of aging women in households we all grew up watching, who do not defend men's hypocrisy, blinded by conditioning. They defend it because they have no other world to belong to. The younger generation, depicted through the chameleonic Ajit Singh Palwat's Parag, becomes lumpenised and transactional as capitalist mores invade the village. The escalating agrarian distress and drought in the text serve as both a physical reality and an existential condition. Uma Katju, as Prabha, embodies this gradual diminishing of the spirit.

Through the Deshpande family's generational saga, Anuradha Kapur maps the transformation of post-Independence India.

The characters don't speak in the distinct Maharashtrian cadence of the text. The linguistic shift to North Indian dialects creates dissonance at times, pulling the audience slightly out of the carefully-constructed Vidarbha setting.

In condensing the trilogy, the narrative inevitably suffers from sudden jumps. The final act takes a stylistic turn, becoming heavily symbolic and philosophical, a shift that breaks away from the grounded progression of the said and the unsaid that Anuradha established so meticulously in the beginning and followed well past the halfway point.

That said, it is hard to look away from this hypnotic mirror to our times to the very end.

